Palestine rapidly escalated into savage violence as these Jewish groups faced armed Arab groups.

The day after the UN resolution recommending the partition of Palestine was passed in November 1947, two buses carrying Jewish passengers were attacked, leaving seven dead and many more wounded. On December 30, members of Irgun threw two bombs into a group of Arab workers outside a British-owned and operated oil refinery in Haifa. Six people were killed and more than forty wounded. Minutes later, Arab workers in the refinery turned on Jewish workers, killing 39 before British troops finally arrived to end the violence. In reprisal, troops from Haganah attacked two Arab villages, killing up to 70 people. This cycle of violence and counter-violence only grew worse during 1948.

The Arab Liberation Army (ALA) was a volunteer army led by a Lebanese-born Arab nationalist named Fawzi al-Qawuqji. With volunteers from other nations and local Palestinian fighters, the ALA amounted to a force of almost 10,000 troops. In February and March 1948, ALA troops began attacking Jewish convoys and established what amounted to a siege of the city of Jerusalem. Beginning in April, Haganah mounted a major and successful counter-offensive against these forces, gaining control of important routes and ensuring that supplies could once again reach Jerusalem.

However, Jewish control of these routes meant severe disruption of supplies to Arab areas and villages. By early May 1948, Haganah troops were in control of areas of Palestine that had been promised to Jewish settlers by the UN resolution as well as areas that had been designated for Palestinian people. As a result, an exodus of an estimated 250,000 civilians began to leave their homes in Palestine and to flee across the border to neighboring Arab countries. With this, the civil war in Palestine was largely over. Haganah was in control in many areas, including the major city of Tel Aviv, parts of Jerusalem, parts of the Coastal Plain, the Jezreel Valley, and the Jordan Valley. The forces of the ALA had been either defeated in combat or forced to flee from Palestine.

But the tidy division of Mandatory Palestine into separate Arab and Jewish zones envisaged by the UN resolution clearly wasn't going to happen—many parts of the region that had been planned to be Arab-governed were now under the control of Haganah. Haganah justified their occupation on the grounds that Jewish cities and